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YARDENI QUICKTAKES

US MARKET CALL: Still Targeting 8400, But Raising Odds Of Bearish Outcome To 30%

By Ed Yardeni & Toby Hearst • 12 Sept 2026

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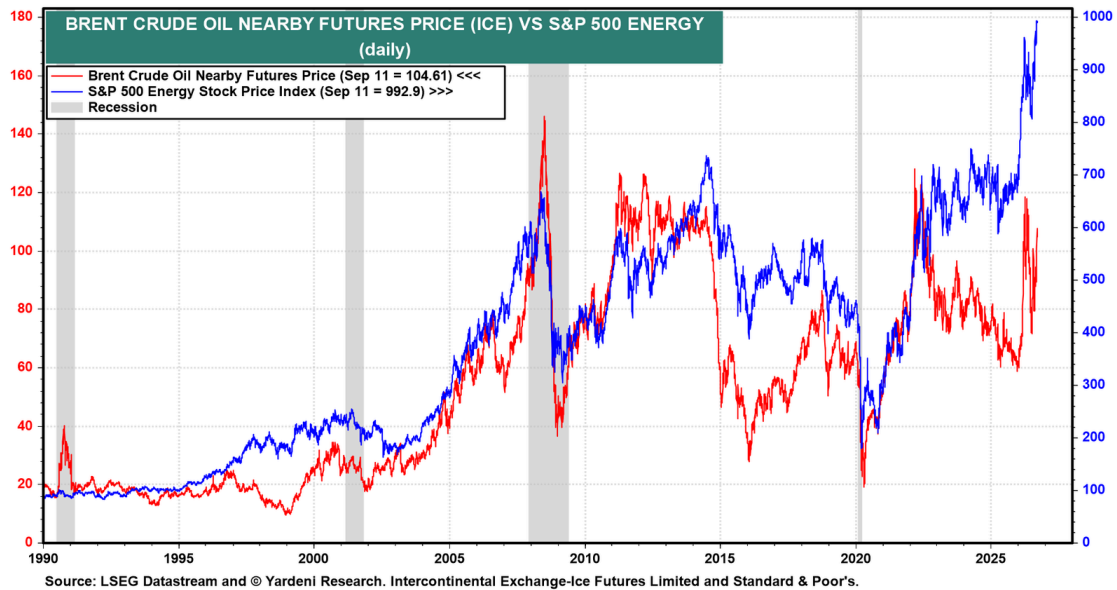
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I. Performance

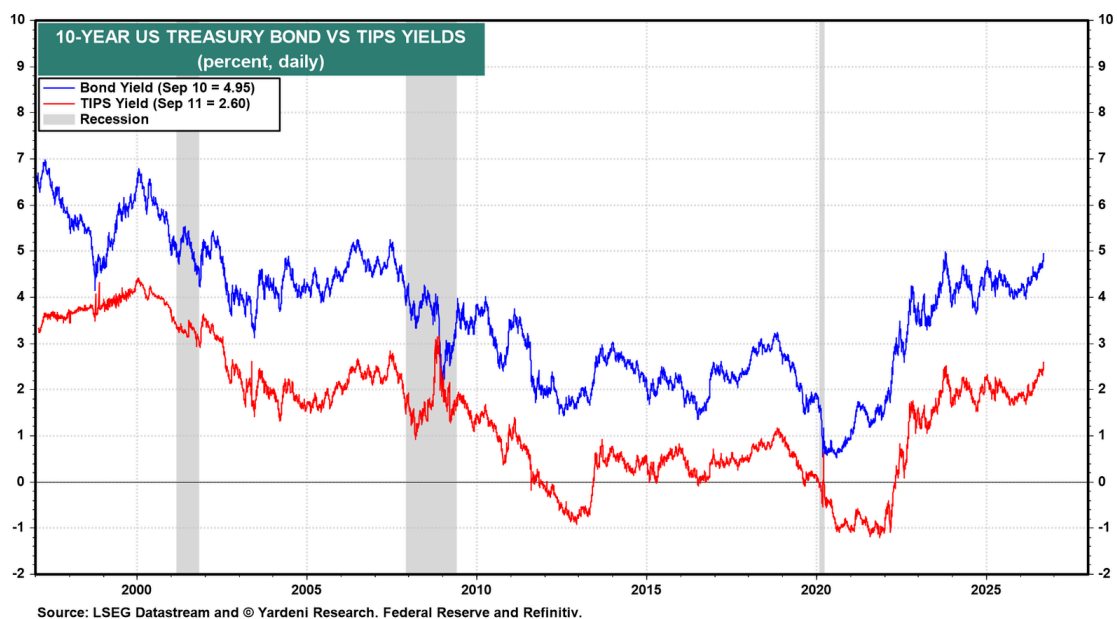
The good news is that our recommendation to overweight the S&P 500 Energy sector is working well (chart). The bad news is that it is doing so because the war in the Middle East has re-escalated. Saudi Arabia has shut down its East-West pipeline as a precaution after a drone attack that originated in Iraq. The pipeline had been moving 4 million to 5 million barrels of oil per day, amounting to 4% to 5% of global supply.

Oil prices shot up over the past week, and the retail price of diesel in the United States surged past a record-high \$6 a gallon. Jacking the prices

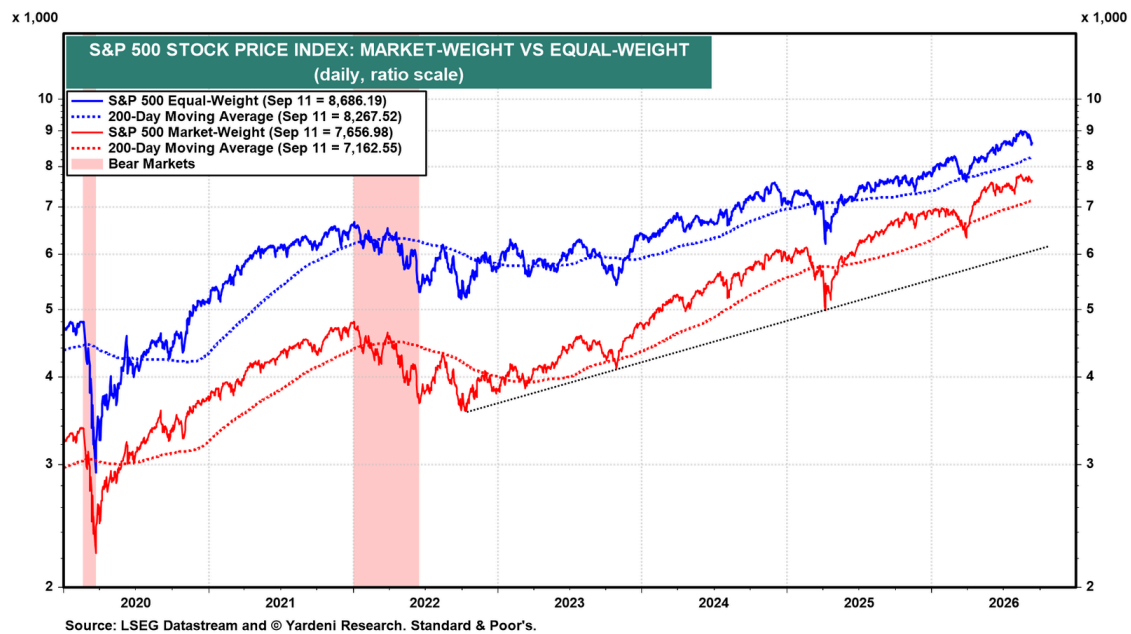
were two developments: The US and Iran both fired on oil tankers, and the Iran-aligned Houthis in Yemen advanced along the Red Sea, potentially extending disruption to another major oil route. If the Houthis close the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, that would deal another economic blow, constraining another 7% of global petroleum supplies and about 12% of global trade.



The latest rebound in oil prices above \$100 a barrel boosted the 10-year US Treasury bond yield to nearly 5.00% and the comparable TIPS yield to 2.60% (chart). Yields are rising on fears that the war in the Middle East is far from over, resulting in higher-for-longer oil prices. If so, then the latest oil shock could spread inflationary pressures in the economy. That would increase the odds of a prolonged Fed rate-hiking cycle.

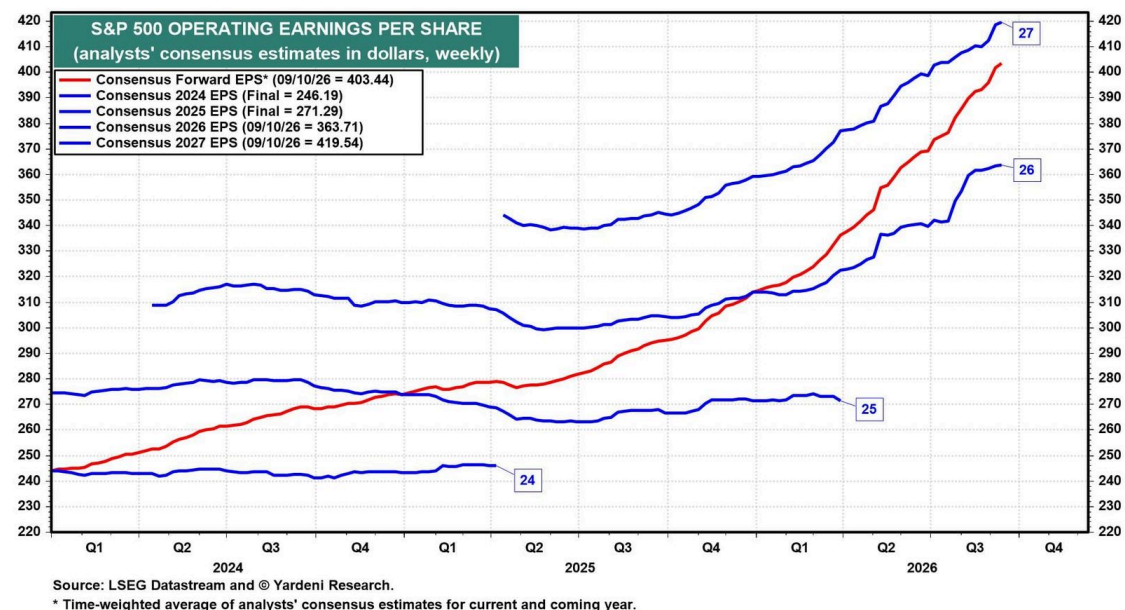


Yet the S&P 500 is down just 1.8% from its record high of 7798.99 on August 13 (chart). Over that same period, the equal-weight version of the index is down 3.5%.

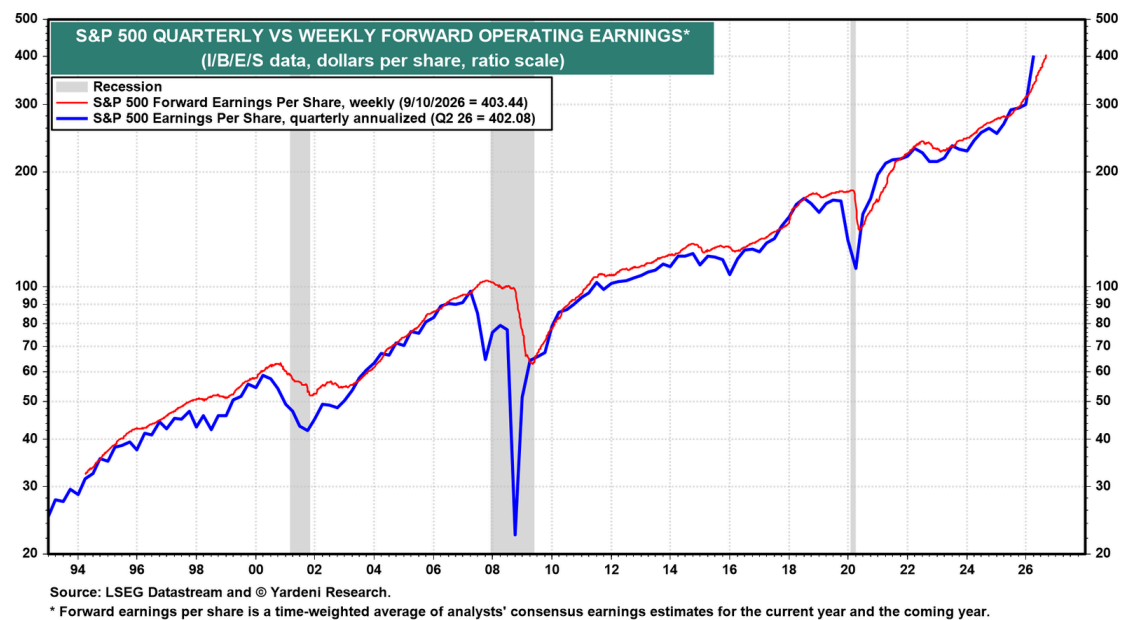


II. Earnings

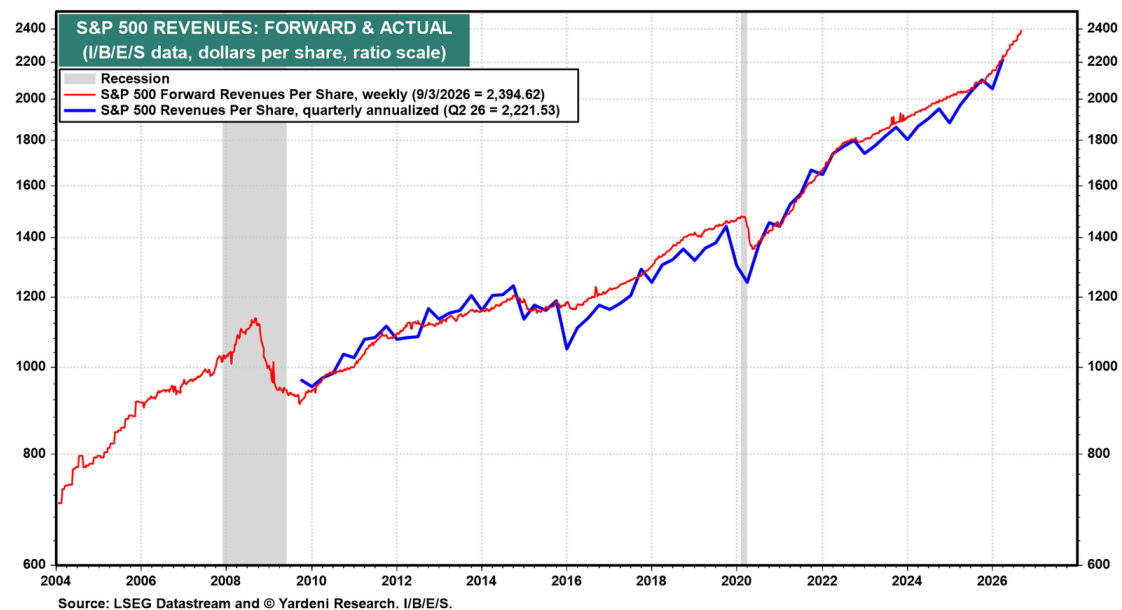
FEMO (Fabulous Earnings Momentum) continues to support stock prices despite the latest troubling developments. The S&P 500 forward earnings has risen to a record \$403.44 per share (chart). By definition, it is approaching the analysts' consensus 2027 EPS estimate and will converge with that estimate by year-end. The consensus has risen to \$419.54, and we think it could rise further to \$425 by year-end. By the way, the 2027 estimate is not distorted by mark-to-market (MTM) capital gains, as is the 2026 estimate.



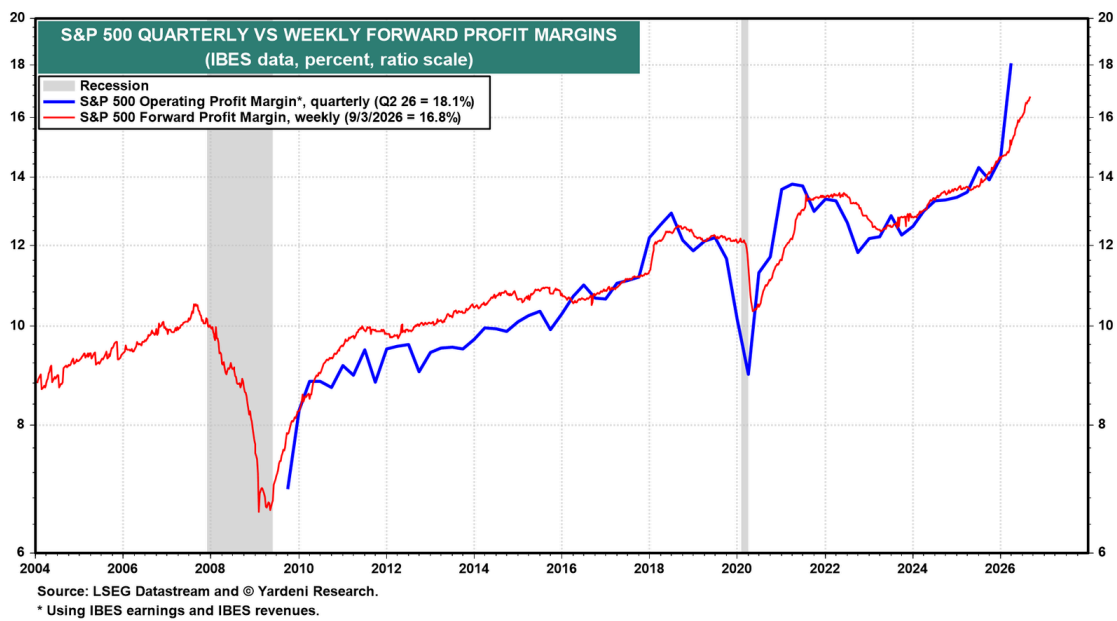
S&P 500 forward earnings has been rising at a faster pace in recent weeks (chart). This suggests that the underlying trend in actual earnings (excluding the recent MTM gains) remains very strongly to the upside.



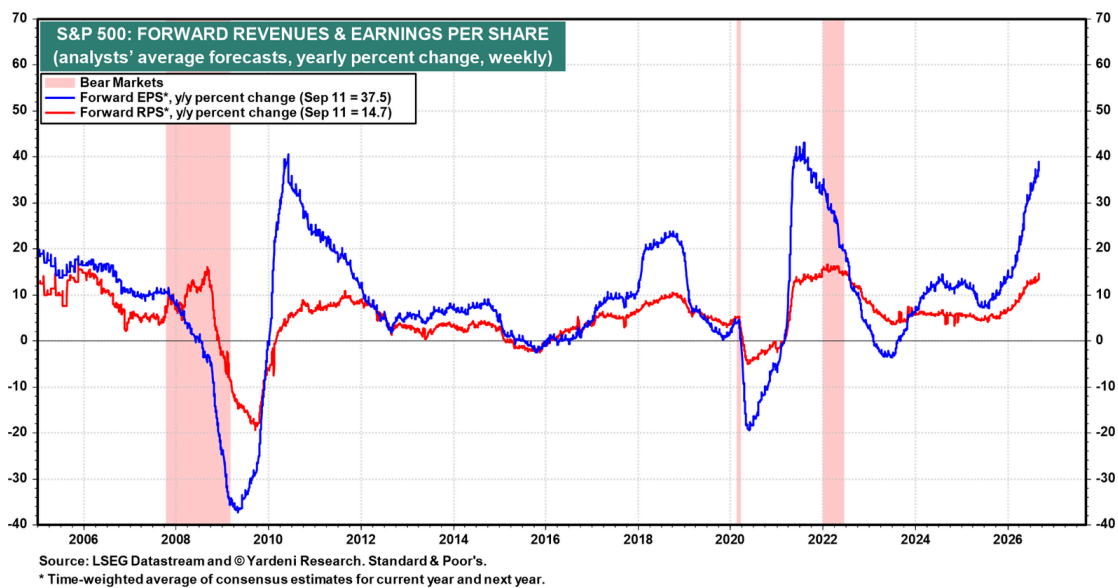
FEMO can be explained by the surprisingly strong pace of S&P 500 revenue growth (chart). It has accelerated this year, notwithstanding rising oil prices and bond yields.



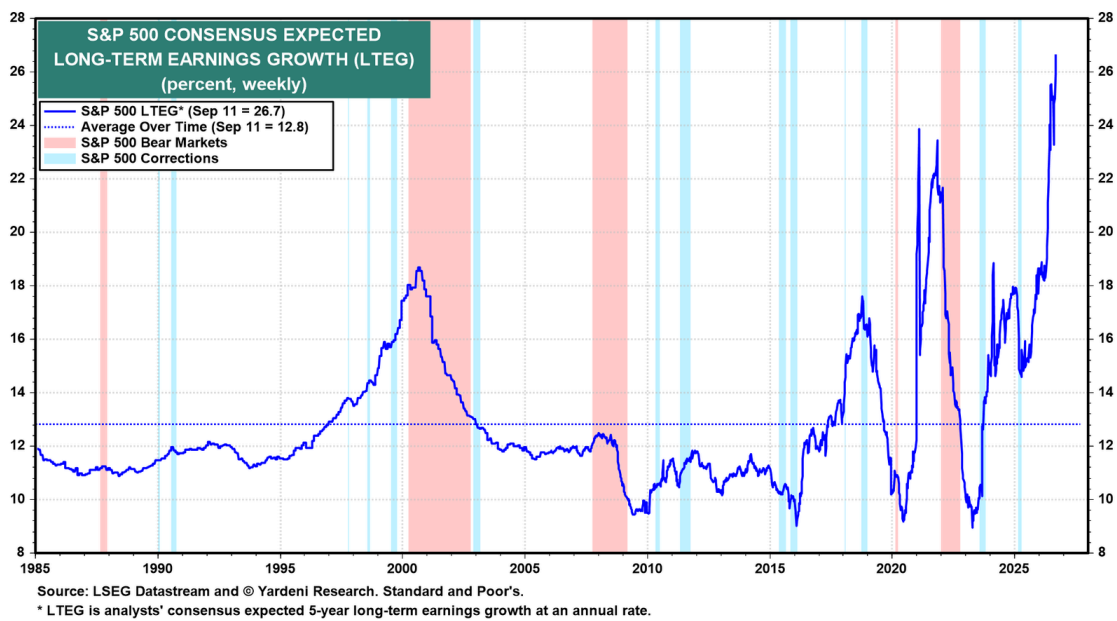
FEMO has also gotten a big boost from a spike in the S&P 500 profit margin (chart). The S&P 500 forward profit margin rose to a record-high 16.8% in early September, confirming that the trend is solidly to the upside even excluding the MTM distortion during the first two quarters of this year.



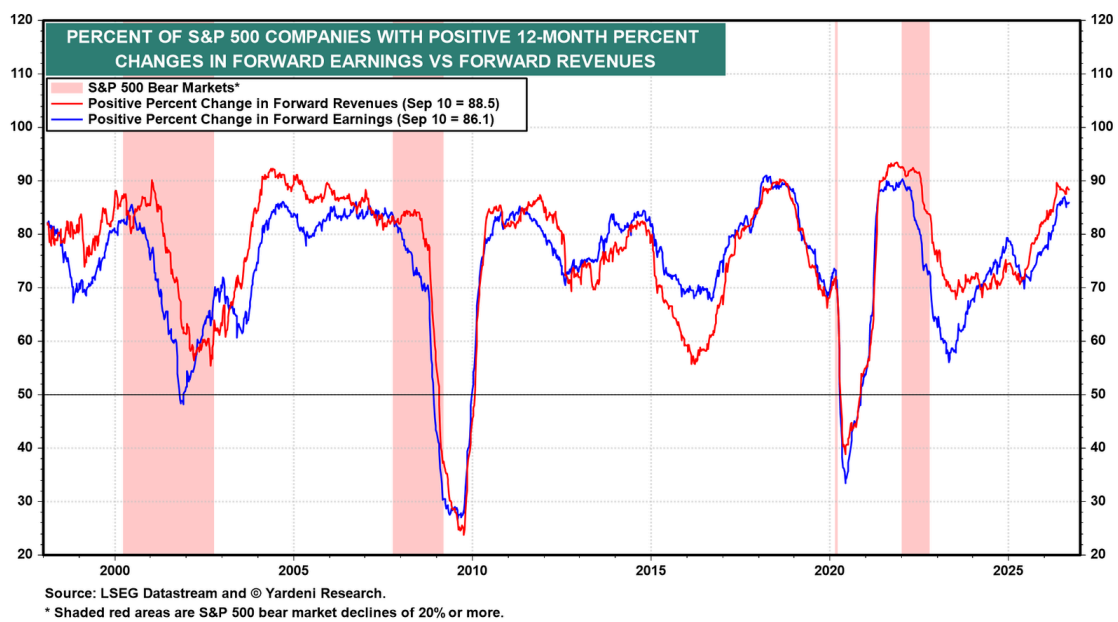
On a y/y basis, there is no sign of any slowdowns in the growth rates of either S&P 500 forward revenues or S&P 500 forward earnings (chart).



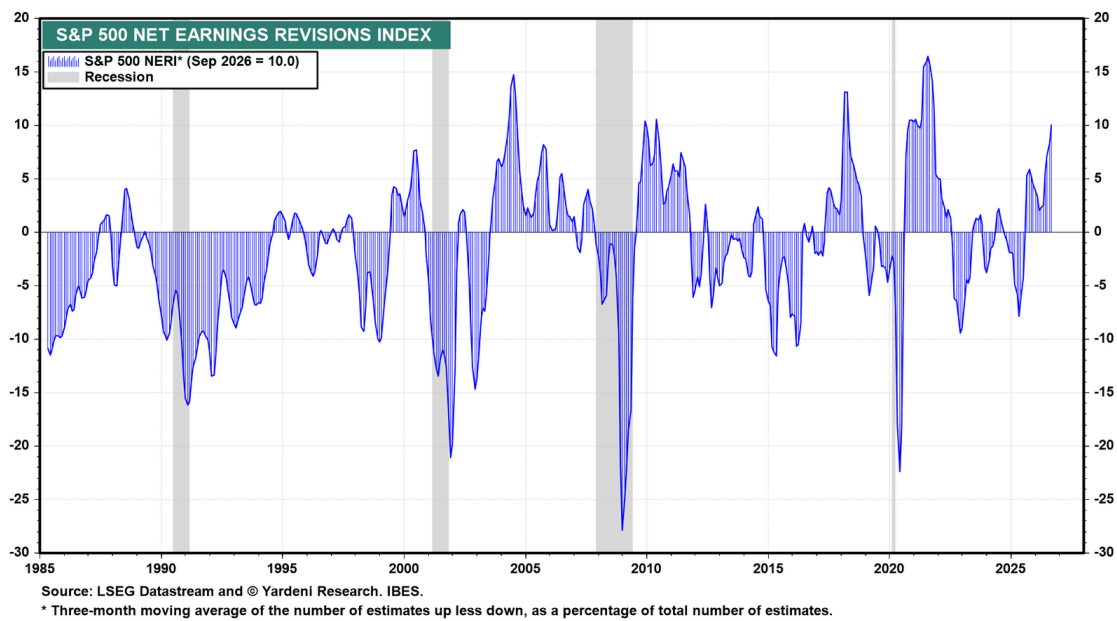
Even more remarkable is that analysts' consensus long-term earnings growth (LTEG) expectation continues to rise to record highs (chart). Last week, LTEG rose to 26.7%. Of course, such a rate of growth would be impossible given that nominal GDP growth is well below that. However, it reflects analysts' collective exuberance about the earnings prospects of the companies they follow.



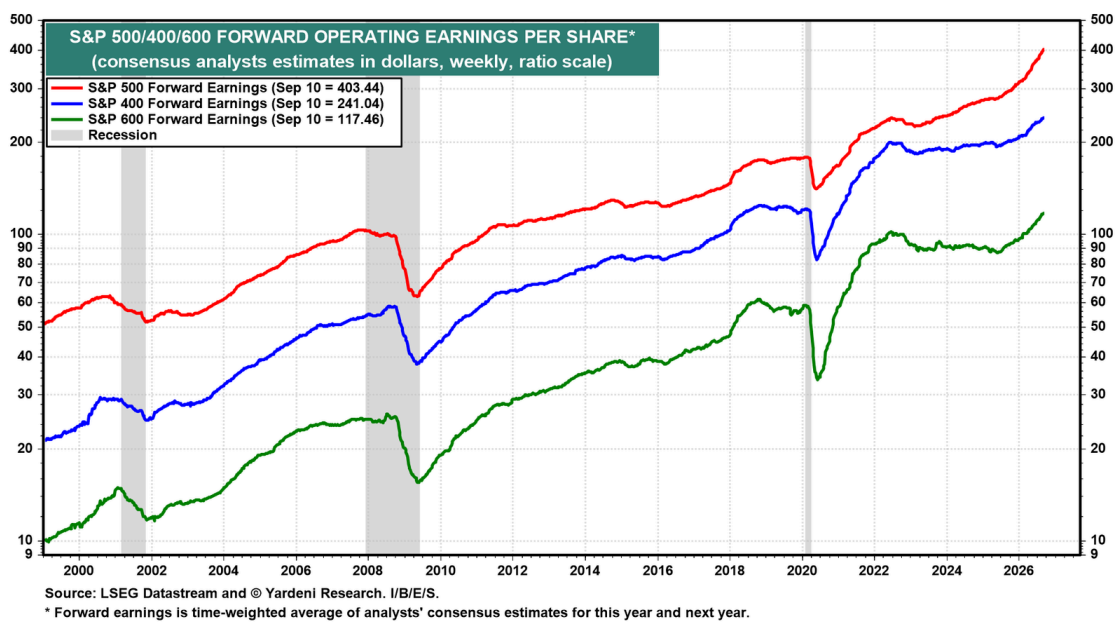
The dispersion of positive y/y percentage changes in S&P 500 forward revenues and forward earnings remains very high (chart).



The S&P 500 Net Earnings Revisions Index also rose to a cyclical high in September (chart).

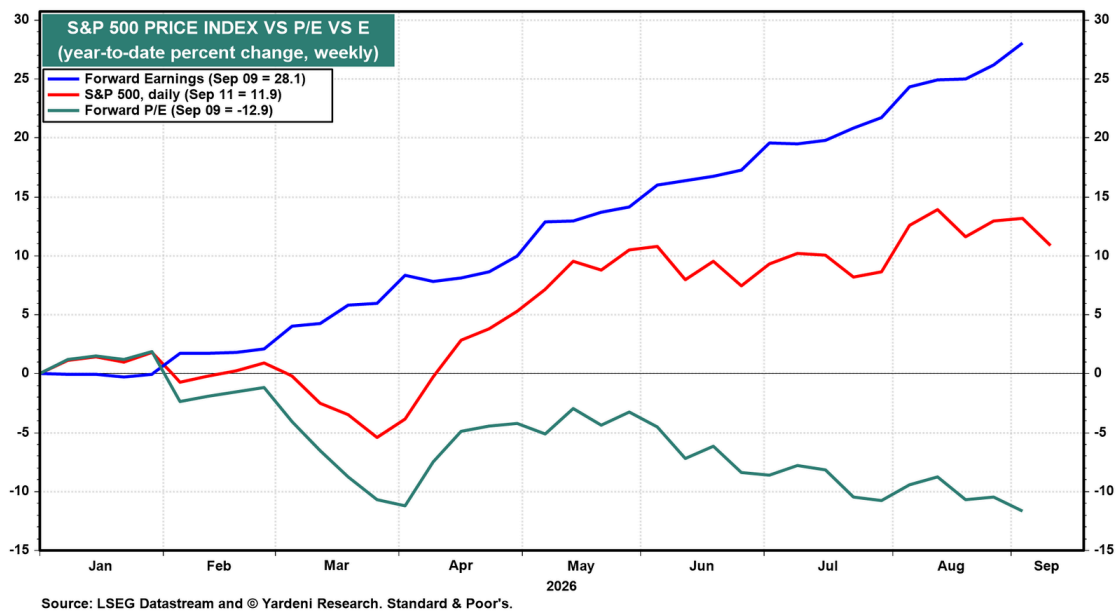


The forward earnings of the S&P 500, S&P 400, and S&P 600 all rose to record highs last week (chart).

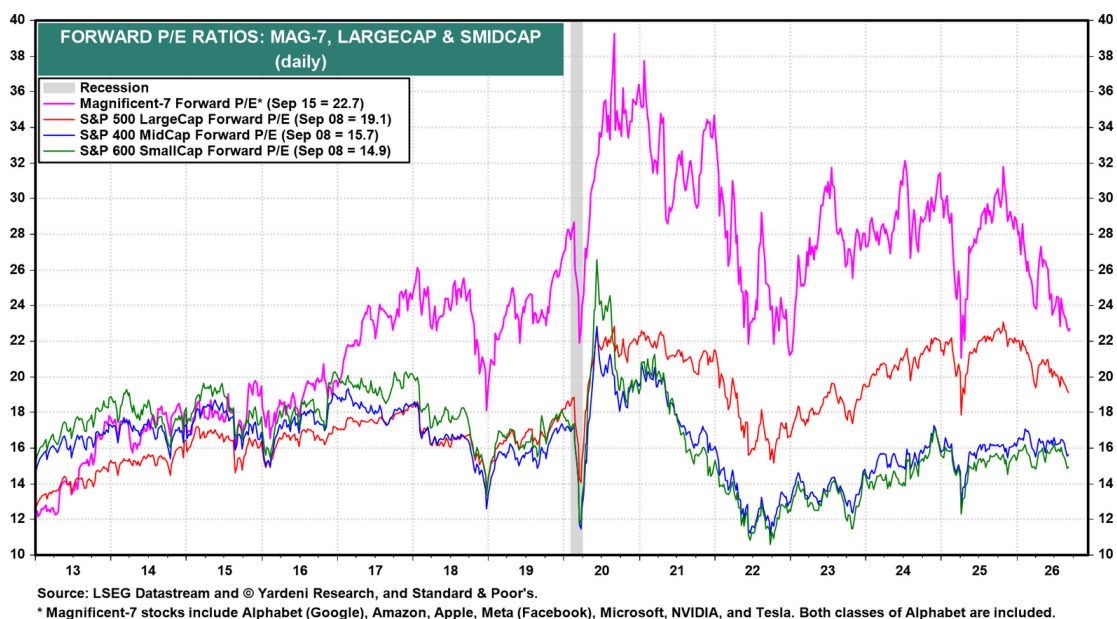


III. Valuation

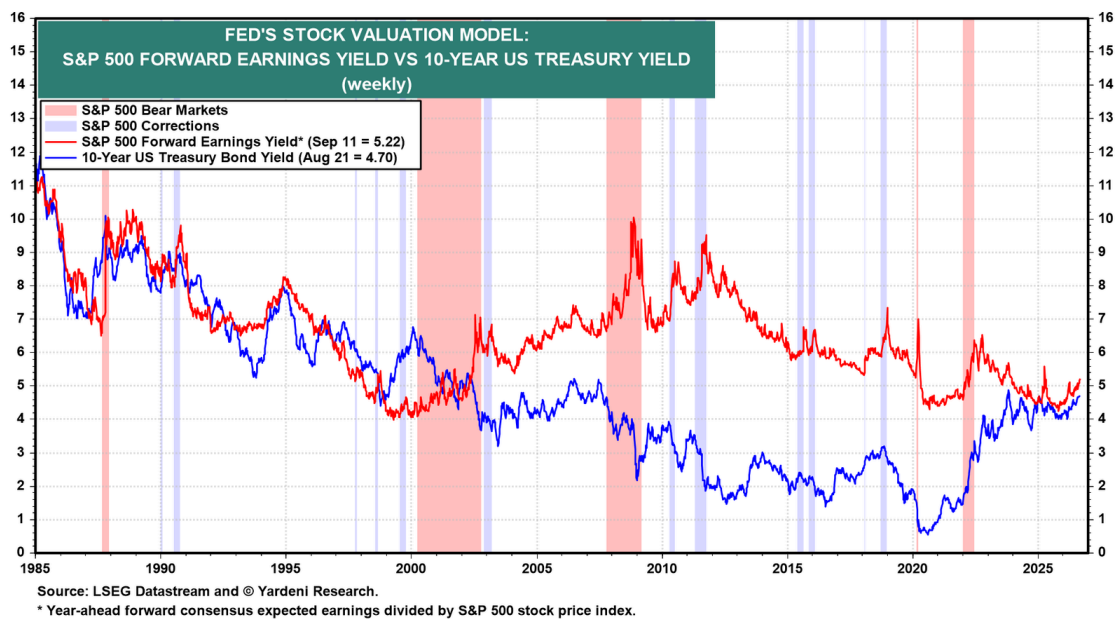
Since the start of the year, the S&P 500's forward earnings has risen 28.1%, while its forward P/E has fallen 12.9% ytd (chart). Investors aren't willing to pay as much for FEMO as they were in January. They may be concerned that analysts' EPS projections reflect a fair amount of irrational exuberance, even though that exuberance has been fueled by actual EPS results!



In recent weeks, the forward P/Es of the major market indexes have declined as forward EPS estimates have outpaced stock price gains (chart). FEMO has been partially offset by less FOMO!



Also weighing on forward P/Es has been the rise in bond yields (chart). We are still projecting 8400 for the S&P 500 by the end of the year. That target might be hit with stronger forward earnings and a weaker forward P/E than we had expected. So we are raising our 2027 earnings estimate to \$425 per share from \$415 and lowering our forward P/E expectation to 19.7 from 20.2.



IV. Sentiment

Admittedly, recent developments in the oil and bond markets are unnerving. We are acknowledging that by lowering the odds of our Roaring 2020s scenario through the end of the decade from 80% to 70%. We are raising the odds of a more bearish outcome from 20% to 30%.

September has often been the toughest month of the year for stock investors. That could be the case this year too. The bull-bear ratios we track could fall sharply over the rest of the month because of the concerns we discussed above (chart). From a contrarian perspective, we would welcome that as a strong buying signal.



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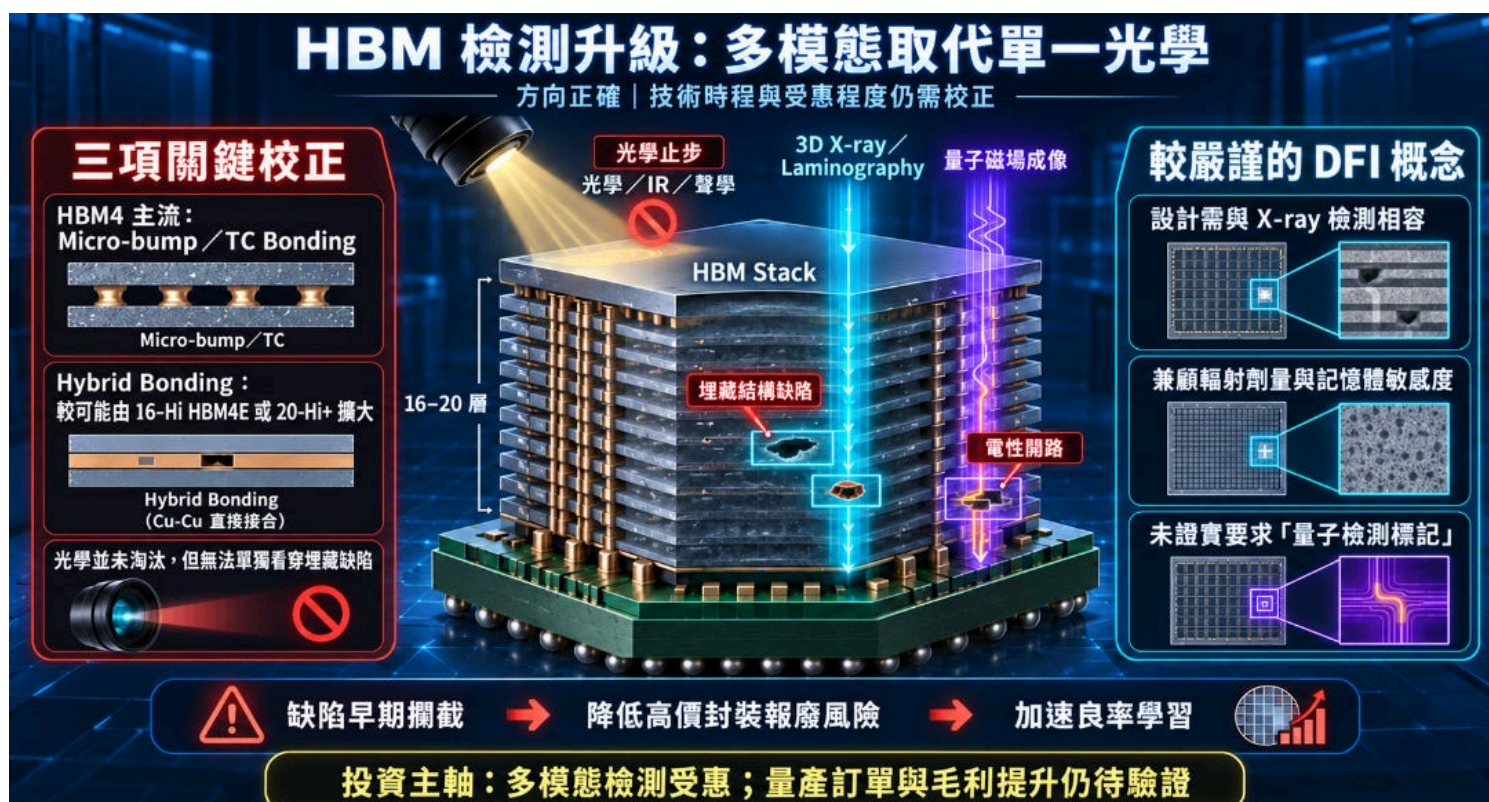
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What's new?

在 SEMICON Taiwan 2026 閉幕日，台積電先進封裝品質與可靠性技術團隊針對次世代 HBM4 / HBM4E 提出呼籲：建議全球三大記憶體原廠（SK 海力士、三星電子、美光）在 HBM 晶粒設計初期就必須納入「可檢測性設計（Design for Inspection, DFI）」，應配置專屬的 X 光繞射（X-ray Diffraction/Metrology）與量子感測檢測標記。隨著 3D 混合鍵合（Hybrid Bonding）將晶粒間距微縮至數微米且堆疊層數高達 16-20 層，傳統光學檢測已徹底陷入「物理全盲」，若無穿透式 X 光與量子感測輔助，台積電 CoWoS-L / SoIC 的系統組裝良率可能將受到影響。



Positive Impacts to the key supply chain vendors

付費訂閱戶可分享主要受惠及受影響廠商及產業的結構性變化及風險評估

- **直接度較高：Rigaku、QuantumDiamonds、宜特。** Rigaku已有針對HBM／Hybrid Bonding的3D laminography設備供客戶評估；宜特已安裝亞洲首套QDm.1。但QuantumDiamonds目前仍主要處於故障分析與邁向inline驗證階段，不能直接推論爆發性量產訂單。
- **具能力、但財務貢獻待確認：閎康、汎銓。** 兩家公司確實具有高解析3D X-ray與封裝失效分析能力；因此受惠邏輯成立。
- **廣義檢測受惠、不能全部歸類為穿透式X-ray：KLA、Bruker、Nova。** Bruker具X-ray薄膜、材料與封裝金屬量測；KLA涵蓋Hybrid Bonding檢測及DRAM X-ray dimensional metrology；Nova的WMC主要仍是光學與尺寸計量平台，而非深層X-ray缺陷成像。

Who can be hurt the most?

- **缺乏先進 X 光與計量設計儲備的記憶體原廠**：若無法即時符合台積電 DFI 規範，其 HBM4 / HBM4E 晶圓將面臨無法通過台積電先進封裝進料檢驗（IQC）而被退貨的嚴重風險。
- 傳統僅依賴表面光學檢測（AOI）的低階檢測設備供應商，在 3D 堆疊晶圓市場將被淘汰。

Advice to investors:

- 佈局「半導體檢測計量學（Metrology & Inspection）新藍海」：3D 混合鍵合時代，「看得到缺陷」比「製造缺陷」更具溢價，加碼布局先進 X 光/量子計量設備與第三方分析實驗室龍頭。
- 密切追蹤記憶體三雄在台積電 HBM4 DFI 驗證的進度差異，此為決定 2027 年 HBM 配額的隱形關鍵。

Outside the box Non-consensus thinking:

「3D 晶片堆疊的阿基里斯腱不是鍵合難度，而是『黑盒子良率黑洞』：計量學正在成為先進封裝的最高定價節點」，市場習慣聚焦於 ASML 曝光機的精度或台積電的鍵合機台，但在 20 層 HBM 的立體微結構中，只要底層一顆微凸塊出現空洞（Void），整顆價值數萬美元的 GPU+HBM 複合模組就會瞬間報廢。台積電要求原廠從設計端就為 X 光檢測開路，揭示了先進封裝的本質已從「機械裝配」昇華為「穿透式微觀物理診斷」。誰能掌控檢測計量標準，誰就掌握了 3D 晶片製造的生殺大權。

Risks to our analysis

一、證據不足

- 「**台積電強制要求SK海力士、三星、美光導入DFI規範。**」
公開資訊僅能確認台積電呼籲未來HBM／DRAM設計提高X-ray檢測相容性，尚無正式強制規格、生效日期或指定廠商名單。
- 「**不符合DFI規範的HBM晶圓將無法通過台積電IQC並被退貨。**」
目前沒有公開的IQC條款或退貨標準。較合理的說法是：可能增加資格驗證難度、缺陷逃逸風險及客戶採用疑慮。
- 「**DFI驗證進度將決定2027年HBM配額。**」
DFI可能成為認證因素之一，但配額仍取決於頻寬、功耗、良率、可靠性、散熱、價格、產能及客戶認證。

二、技術概念混淆及錯誤

- 「**HBM4／HBM4E已普遍採用Hybrid Bonding。**」
目前HBM4主流仍以micro-bump／TC Bonding為主；Hybrid Bonding較可能由部分16-Hi HBM4E或20-Hi以上世代逐步擴大。
- 「**X-ray與量子感測是同一套DFI檢測標記。**」
兩者原理不同：X-ray觀察結構與材料差異；量子鑽石顯微鏡則偵測電流產生的磁場，兩者屬互補檢測方式。
- 「**QuantumDiamonds已經進入HBM大量inline檢測。**」
現階段已有商用故障分析設備及inline技術里程碑，但尚不能證明已在HBM量產線形成大規模全檢訂單。
- 「**傳統光學檢測已徹底陷入物理全盲。**」
可見光確實無法單獨看穿完成鍵合後的深層結構，但光學、IR／SWIR、聲學、e-beam及電性測試仍可用於不同製程節點。
- 「**僅依賴AOI的設備商將被徹底淘汰。**」

低階純2D AOI的相對價值可能下降，但表面顆粒、pad形貌、對位、翹曲及高速篩檢仍需光學設備。產業趨勢是多模態整合，而非AOI消失。

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